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Siaya

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The positions were resumed and Nashon handed the sub-chief a packet of bills folded tightly. The packet was handed around, with each elder asking another to count it. The uncle slowly counted the money and announced that it was 'nine hundred and ninety'. Elijah asked for a recount and the sub-chief slowly counting aloud again reached one thousand. Then the sub-chief spoke:

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'I have never seen a case where people came to pay bridewealth before an "agreement fee" was paid and before the "food fee" was paid ... therefore let us divide this money up and see what is left as bridewealth. Even if you boys think that this thousand shillings should be kept as one, maybe all that will remain as bridewealth will be five bob ... and then Adhiambo's husband will have to settle the rest before we proceed with these negotiations.'

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There was a lengthy discussion about the differences in practice between Alego and Yimbo in the disposition of marriage payments. Finally, the uncle conceded that the funds would be treated as bridewealth in their entirety.

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The record-player was brought back to the room and there was music and dancing, with a good deal of teasing and joking between the *jogam* and Adhiambo's people. Eventually, the gathering broke up and the visitors were shown sleeping places in one of the houses in the compound. Before going to sleep, Daudi, Nashon, Elijah, and Ochanda discussed the long day's negotiation and felt that they had done well for their comrade, Adhiambo's husband.

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The next morning breakfast was served in Adhiambo's mother's house and the mother spoke up for the first time:

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'I really had hope in Atieno's father [that is, the groom, Adhiambo's husband – Atieno was Adhiambo's young daughter]. But now I have lost hope in him completely, because since Adhiambo married him he has not written to us once and since Adhiambo came back from him two months ago he has not even written to Adhiambo or anyone else here to find out about Adhiambo's whereabouts. The father of Atieno is a person whose behaviour we know too well. Ever since he took Adhiambo three years ago we have not asked him for anything ... a poor person pays bridewealth with his eyes. The fathers of Adhiambo's husband have not come here either and show that they are also useless ... neither have they written. With me I have no problem ... when writing to Atieno's father tell him that his mother-in-law wanted to smack the *jogam* because he was not here himself to take the punishment that he deserves.'

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As they went to their car, Adhiambo, with Atieno at her side, came over and said that she would not leave now, but would wait for word from her husband. Except for this small group,  109 the compound was empty. The journey back to Boro was a long one.

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